Margot Berthelin

Zurich, Switzerland

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Presentation

In my research, I investigate meaning attribution in prelinguistic infants' vocalizations. I use machine learning methods to uncover acoustic features correlated with consistent meaning and I conduct experiments to assess cross-cultural comprehension of these vocal cues. As a member of the Animal Meaning Task, I collaborate with animal behavior experts. We explore evolutionary continuities in meaning assignment across species, designing methodologies adaptable both to human and non-human animal vocalizations.

Experience

University of Zurich — **Zurich, Switzerland**
PhD in Language Acquisition, under the supervision of Sabine Stoll and Klaus Zuberbühler — *July 2024 – Present*

- Studying meaning in early infancy: prelinguistic vocalisations and the functions they carry, using machine learning and experimental methods.
- Co-supervision of Master's theses.
- Teaching duties in language acquisition mechanisms, general linguistics, morphology.

Advance Ticket GmbH — **Remote/Geneva, Switzerland**
Web Developer — *March 2023 - June 2024*

- Modernising the Ticketing App, automating redundant tasks, solving bugs and offering better client support, developing internal tools.

KVZ and Movetia Assistant Program — **Zurich, Switzerland**
French language assistant — *September 2020 – June 2022*

- Teaching French to 14-19 year old students in a vocational high school (commercial and business)

Duolingo, Freelance — **Remote**
FR-EN-ZH translator and content creator — *January 2019 – February 2020*

- Sentence translation from Chinese to French and from Chinese to English.
- Improving user experience: detection of bugs and troubleshooting.

University Taras Shevchenko, with the French ministry of Defense — **Kyiv, Ukraine**
visiting French language lecturer — *September 2018 – July 2019*

- Teaching French in the Defense department of the University, students with mixed levels (A1 to C2).
- Focusing on diplomacy, journalistic discourse, formal conversation.

University Stefan Cel Mare — **Suceava, Romania**
visiting French language lecturer — *September 2017 – July 2018*

- Teaching to students in linguistics major (levels from B1 to C2): Advanced French language classes, grammar, didactics, French literature.

Education

University of Zurich — **Zurich, Switzerland**
PhD in Language Acquisition (**Supervisor: Sabine Stoll**) *July 2024 – Present*
Thesis "Meaning in prelinguistic infants' vocalisations"

LeWagon — **Zurich, Switzerland**
Data Science Bootcamp Sept 2022 – Dec 2022

University of Avignon - Pays du Vaucluse **Avignon, France**
Master's in linguistics (**Supervisor: Anika Falkert**) *September 2015 - July 2017*
Thesis "Liaison phenomenon in French and how to teach it to second language learners? Comparing inductive and deductive learning approaches"

Seminar talks and Poster Presentations

07 November 2026: BUCLD 51 **Boston University, United States of America**
Boston University Conference on Language Developement
Poster: Adults rely on point-accompanying vocalisations when interpreting an infant's intention

23 September 2026: X-PPL **IKER-CNRS, University of Pau, Bayonne, France**
Conference on Crosslinguistic Perspectives on Processing and Learning
Poster: Adults rely on infant vocalisations when interpreting the intention of their points

29 and 20 August 2026: Scientifica **UZH and ETH, Zurich, Switzerland**
Outreach booth: presenting research methods on child-directed speech and the influence of its acoustic features on typically-developing children versus on children on the autistic spectrum
Co-hosts: Annika Junker, Giuachin Kreiliger, Julia Ulrich, Agata Mercante.

Organised conferences and workshops

X-PPL 2025 **UZH, Zurich, Switzerland**
part of the organizing committee

Summer School 2027 **UZH, Zurich, Switzerland**
part of the organizing committee

UZH Biacoustics Community **UZH, Zurich, Switzerland**
part of the organizing committee

Skills

Programming: Python, R, HTML/CSS, LaTeX, JavaScript, SQL
Software: Heroku, PsychoPy, DaVinci Resolve

Grants

Research Travel Grant (1500 CHF) for Conference attendance
NCCR Travel Grant (1000 CHF) for Conference attendance